Tech Time: Scroll or Build?

Thinking about technology and game design

Name:_____

Date:_____ Grade:_____

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🚀 Let's Start!

In this activity, you will learn about how you spend time online. You will track your app use and think about how it makes you feel. Then, you will design your own game using what you learned.

Here are some words to know:

- **Dopamine:** A chemical in your brain that makes you feel good. It can come from fun things or easy things.
  - Example: Eating a sweet treat gives you a dopamine rush.
- **Neural Audit:** Checking how your brain reacts to things you do, like using apps.
  - Example: A neural audit can help you see which apps make you happy and which don't.
- **If/Then Logic:** A way of programming where something happens *if* something else is true. *Then* something else will occur as a result.
  - Example: *If* the player touches the coin, *then* they get a point.

Tips for Success

Think about how each app makes you feel. Be honest with yourself. There is no right or wrong answer.

📖 Read the Following Text

Read the following text carefully. You will use it to complete the tasks that follow.

Are You Scrolling or Building?

Today, phones and computers are part of our lives. We use apps to talk to friends, watch videos, and play games. Some apps give us quick fun, like a short video. This is like a sugar rush for your brain. It gives you dopamine fast, but it doesn't last long.

Other apps let you build things, like games or art. These take more time and work. But they can give you a better feeling of joy. It is like planting a garden. You work hard, and then you see it grow. That feels good for a long time.

It's good to know the difference between quick fun and real joy. A neural audit can help you. Look at the apps you use. Do they give you cheap dopamine, or do they help you build something? Think about how you want to spend your time. You can use tech to have fun and learn. It's all about finding the right balance for you.

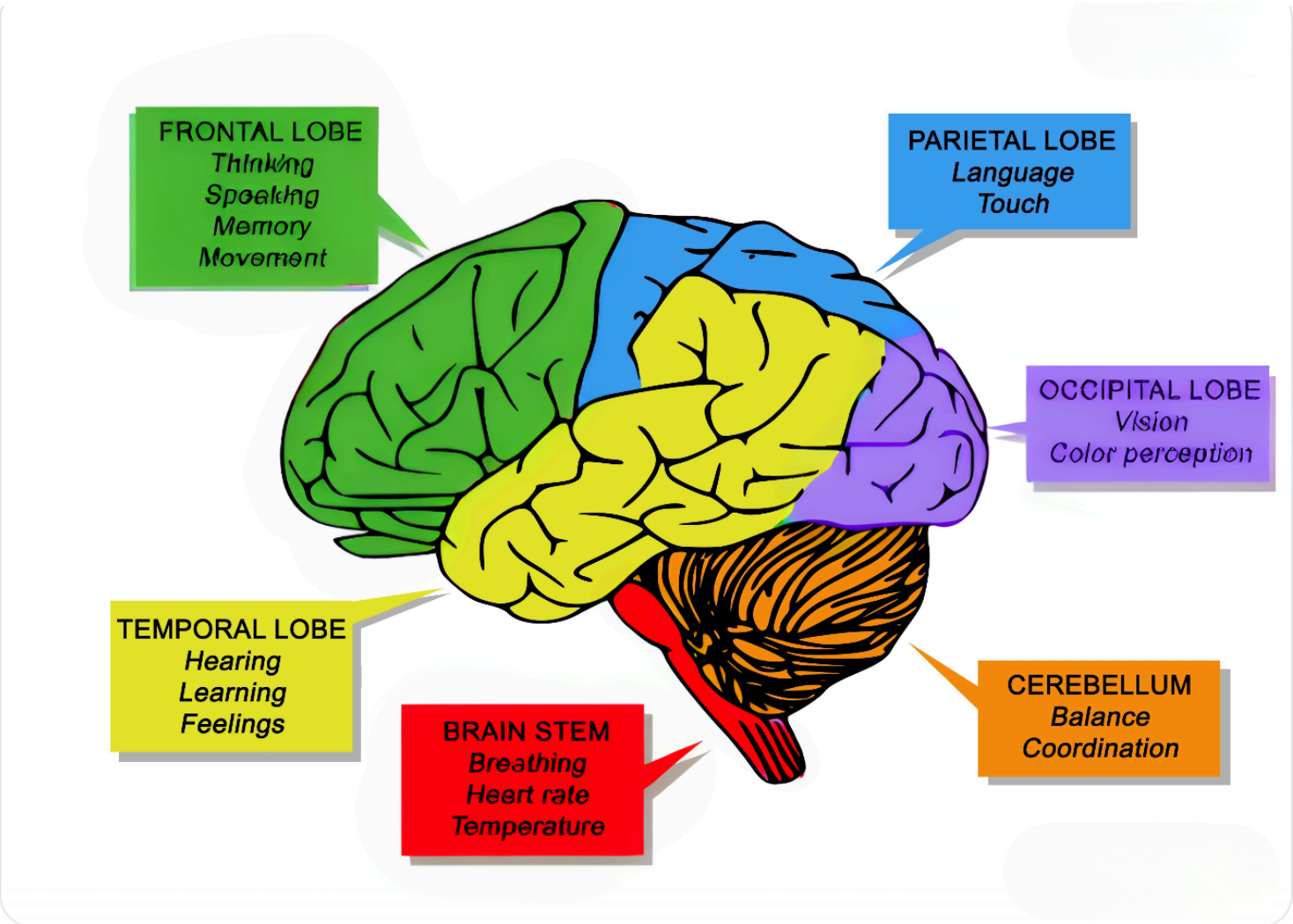
Parts of the Brain

Your Amazing Brain: A Guide to All the Parts

Your brain is like the control center of your body. It's made up of different parts that work together to help you think, move, feel, and stay alive. Let's explore each part and what it does!

Brain Parts Diagram

A side view of the brain showing all the major parts and their functions



Key:

- 🟢 **Frontal Lobe** (red) - Thinking, planning, personality
- 🔵 **Parietal Lobe** (blue) - Touch, spatial awareness
- 🟡 **Temporal Lobe** (yellow) - Hearing, memory, language
- 🟣 **Occipital Lobe** (green) - Vision, visual processing
- 🟠 **Cerebellum** (orange) - Balance, coordination
- 🔴 **Brain Stem** (purple) - Basic life functions

The Cerebrum: Your Thinking Cap

The cerebrum is the biggest part of your brain. It's divided into four main sections called lobes:

Frontal Lobe

- **What it does:** This is your "thinking headquarters"
- **Jobs:** Planning, making decisions, controlling your personality, and moving your muscles
- **Fun fact:** This part isn't fully developed until you're about 25 years old, which is why teenagers sometimes make risky choices!

Parietal Lobe

- **What it does:** Processes information from your senses
- **Jobs:** Helps you understand touch, temperature, pain, and where your body is in space
- **Example:** When you reach for something without looking, this lobe helps guide your hand

Temporal Lobe

- **What it does:** Handles hearing and memory
- **Jobs:** Processing sounds, understanding language, and storing memories
- **Connection to dopamine:** This area works with other brain parts to create those good feelings when you get likes on social media

Occipital Lobe

- **What it does:** All about vision
- **Jobs:** Processing everything you see, recognizing colors, shapes, and movement
- **Cool detail:** Even though your eyes collect the images, this lobe is what actually "sees"

The Cerebellum: Your Balance Master

- **What it does:** Controls balance and coordination
- **Jobs:** Helps you walk, ride a bike, play sports, and move smoothly
- **Size:** It's only about 10% of your brain's weight, but it contains over half of all your brain cells!

The Brain Stem: Your Life Support

- **What it does:** Controls the basic functions that keep you alive
- **Jobs:** Manages breathing, heart rate, blood pressure, and sleep cycles
- **Why it matters:** This part works automatically—you don't have to think about breathing or making your heart beat

How This Connects to Your Digital Life

Remember how we talked about dopamine earlier? Different apps affect these brain parts in different ways:

- **Quick dopamine apps** (like endless scrolling) mainly activate reward centers without engaging your frontal lobe much
- **Building apps** (like coding or creating) activate multiple areas, including your frontal lobe for planning and problem-solving

Understanding your brain helps you make better choices about which apps to use and when. Your frontal lobe—the part that makes good decisions—can help you choose activities that make you feel good for longer periods of time.

Your Brain is Always Growing

The amazing thing about your brain is that it can change and grow throughout your life. When you learn new skills or practice something, you're actually building stronger connections between brain cells. This is why the "building" activities we discussed can be so rewarding—they're literally helping your brain grow stronger!

🔗 Building Connections

As you have learned about building versus scrolling, and the parts of the brain, complete the table below to connect the key ideas and show why they matter.

Key Concept	Your Understanding	Why is this important?
Dopamine	*A chemical that makes you feel good.*	*It helps you know what you like and don't like.*
Cheap Dopamine		
Earned Joy		
Neural Audit		
Frontal Lobe		
Parietal Lobe		
Temporal Lobe		
Occipital Lobe		

Cerebellum		
Brain Stem		

✍️ Try It Out

Now that you have read the text, answer the questions below.

Think about your screen time. Which apps give you 'cheap dopamine?'	
Which apps give you 'earned joy?'	
How can you balance 'cheap dopamine' and 'earned joy' in your life?	

🎬 Show What You Learned

Now that you have learned about apps, create a digital visual to show your understanding.

Follow the steps below to complete your creative output:

- Think of a game idea that teaches others about 'cheap dopamine' versus 'earned joy'.
- Write down the main parts of your game. What will players do?
- Draw pictures of your game. Show the world and the characters.
- Add text to explain your game. What is the goal? What happens if you win or lose?
- Share your digital visual with the class. Explain your idea. Use Magic Media or Elements to help storyboard or record your idea.

Reflect on Your Knowledge Transfer

Now that you've explored how ideas can move from understanding to real-world use, take a moment to look back on how you connected concepts, recognized patterns, and applied them to new situations.

How did tracking your app use change how you think about your time online?

What was the hardest part of designing a game about 'cheap dopamine' and 'earned joy'?

How can you use what you learned today to make better choices about your screen time?